

# Wizard of Oz Prototype

*Fake the back-end to test the front-end experience*

## PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

In a Wizard of Oz prototype, users interact with what looks like an automated system while a human secretly performs the back-end functions. It tests desirability and the experience of a capability before that capability is actually built.

## WHO DEVELOPED IT

Named after the 1900 story's 'man behind the curtain'; established in HCI research in the 1980s (Kelley, 1983).

## WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Some experiences (AI assistants, recommendation engines) are expensive to build. Faking the back-end lets teams test whether users even want the experience before investing.

## HOW IT IS USED

Design a realistic front-end, have a hidden operator generate the responses in real time, and observe how users react as if the system were real.

## WHEN IT IS USED

Prototyping capabilities that are costly or slow to build, especially interactive or 'intelligent' features.

## BY WHOM IT IS USED

UX researchers, product teams and AI/service designers.

## INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It decouples **desirability testing** from **feasibility**, letting teams validate demand before committing engineering effort.

## RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Paper / Low-fi Prototype *Slibrary 8*

Solution Interview *Slibrary 9*

## SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Kelley, J.F. (1984) 'An iterative design methodology for user-friendly natural language office information applications', *ACM ToIS*, 2(1), pp. 26–41.  
Buxton, B. (2007) *Sketching User Experiences*. San Francisco: Morgan Kaufmann.

FIGURE 1 · HIDDEN HUMAN OPERATOR

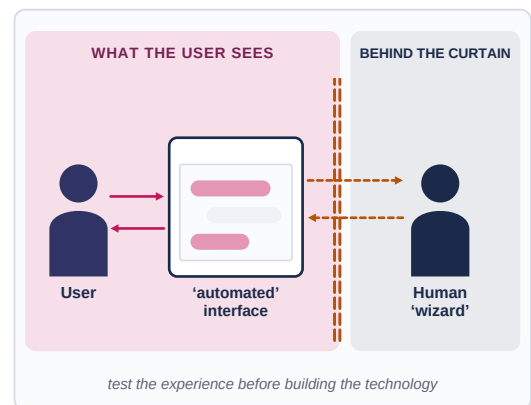


Figure 1. The user believes the system is automated while a hidden person produces its responses.